

Chapter 14: The Moment She Stops Running

The next morning, Jenny arrived earlier than usual.

Not because she wanted to.

Because she couldn't sleep.

Again.

She told herself it was stress.

Work stress.

Family stress.

Life stress.

Anything except the truth she didn't want to name.

The restaurant was quiet before opening.

Empty tables.

Clean floors.

No noise.

No customers.

No Austin Blackwood.

For a moment, she felt relief.

Then the bell above the door rang.

Jenny froze.

Of course.

She didn't even turn around at first.

"Too early for lunch," she said automatically.

"I know."

That voice.

Calm.

Close.

Jenny turned slowly.

Austin stood near the entrance.

Not in his usual composed business posture.

A little less sharp today.

Still expensive.

Still controlled.

But... different.

Jenny frowned.

"You're early."

"I know."

"You already said that."

A faint pause.

"I came to see you before the rush."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Why?"

Austin looked at her for a moment.

Longer than usual.

Then said,

"Because I didn't like how yesterday ended."

Jenny blinked slightly.

"It ended normally."

"No," he said quietly. "It didn't."

A silence stretched between them.

Jenny felt it again.

That pressure in her chest.

She hated it.

"So what?" she asked. "You came to fix it?"

"I came to understand it."

Jenny scoffed lightly.

"You're always trying to understand something."

"Yes."

"That's exhausting."

"Sometimes."

A pause.

Then he stepped closer.

Not too close.

But closer than usual.

"I said something yesterday," he said.

Jenny waited.

"And?"

"I didn't explain it properly."

She frowned.

"You don't have to explain everything you say."

"I think I do."

That surprised her.

Jenny studied him carefully.

"What do you want, Austin?"

Silence.

Not hesitation.

Not avoidance.

Just... thought.

Then—

"I want to stop feeling like I'm pulling you away from yourself."

Jenny went still.

That wasn't what she expected.

Not even close.

She blinked.

"I don't need saving."

"I didn't say you did."

"Then what are you saying?"

Austin looked at her properly now.

"I think I'm affecting you."

Jenny immediately shook her head.

"No."

Too fast.

Too defensive.

Austin noticed.

Of course he did.

"You are," he said gently.

Jenny's voice dropped.

"You don't know me well enough to say that."

A pause.

Then softly—

"Then let me."

That stopped her.

The kitchen behind them was still quiet.

Too quiet.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

"Why?" she asked.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"Because I can't stop thinking about you."

Jenny's breath caught.

She hated that it did.

She tightened her grip on her sleeves.

"That's not a reason."

"It is for me."

Jenny shook her head.

"You don't understand what you're saying."

"I understand more than you think."

"No," she said firmly. "You don't."

A beat.

Then Austin said something quieter.

"Then tell me."

That made her stop.

Tell him?

About what?

About her life?

Her exhaustion?

Her responsibilities?

The way she barely held everything together?

The way she couldn't afford distraction?

Or falling?

Jenny stepped back.

"This is a bad idea."

Austin didn't move.

"I know."

That honesty again.

It made everything worse.

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"You should leave."

"No."

That was immediate.

Simple.

Final.

Jenny looked at him sharply.

"What do you mean no?"

"I mean I'm not leaving."

Silence.

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

"This isn't your place," she said.

"It is when I come here every day."

"That doesn't make it yours."

"I didn't say it was mine."

A pause.

Then softer—

"I said I don't want to leave it."

That sentence hung between them.

Heavy.

Unfinished.

Jenny stared at him.

And for the first time...

She didn't have a quick response.

Behind her, Bao peeked from the kitchen.

Whispering,

“Oh this is serious serious...”

Jenny didn’t even turn around.

Because all she could focus on was the man in front of her.

Standing still.

Not demanding.

Not forcing.

Just staying.

And somehow...

That was the most dangerous thing he had ever done.